

DOCUMENTATION OF RARE BIRD SIGHTING

2005-1 (A)

Species: American Woodcock

Date: 12/31/04 10:30 AM
1/01/05 Time seen: 2:30 PM

Locality: Aurora, Adams County. S.E. of Chambers & Smith Rd - 1/2 mile South of Star K Ranch, Parking lot, along Sand Creek

Lat/long: Optical equipment: No optical Eq. p. could be used.

Number of birds seen: 1 Sex: ? Plumage:

Light conditions: good - Clear sky

Distance from bird: 25ft±

Weather at time of observation: Clear -

Describe habitat: Riparian - stream mostly ice covered.
Cottonwood & Willow Trees with scattered willow/weed understory
Ground cover of fallen leaf litter. First Flushed from wet seep/
Springs at base of steep hillside - 25ft± from Sand Creek.Describe behavior: Flushed suddenly from ground when approached 20-30ft - Flew
up & away and curved down and out of sight on landing - By
spreading out & walking through general area was refloshed
three times. Always landed in dry woodland sites - not grasslandField marks observed: size, color, pattern, shape, bill, etc.: Stream edge.
Similar to snipe but darker brown and plumper less streamline
body. All dark brown upper sides with reddish-brown on both
sides of tail or rump. Undersides unstreaked orange/tan. No
white or white streaking on upper or undersides.
Long straight bill.Bird's call or song: No Vocalizations. Wings made a whistling trill in
flightField marks not seen: Eye, face, undertail, Lower belly. Could not make
out nape or crown details.Similar species and how eliminated: Snipe - No white on undersides - different more
rounded body shape than snipePrior experience with this species: I spent my first 25+ yrs in New Jersey where they
were fairly common.

Description from: [Notes taken in field] [Memory]

Both:

Randy Penh

Name and address

15903A E. Rice PL
Aurora CO 80015

2005-1 (A)

CHRISTMAS BIRD COUNT RARE BIRD DOCUMENTATION FORM

CBC NAME: Sand Creek/Tollgate Creek, Urban Denver count, Denver, CO

Documentation form for unusual bird sightings: submitted as documentation of (check all that apply):

☒ Unusual species ☐ Unusual date ☐ Unusual breeding record ☐ Unusual Habitat
1. Species American Woodcock Age ? Sex ? # 12. Date (s) of Observation 1/1/2005 Time 2:15 PM to 2:40 PMEarlier/Later dates by others, if known Randy Lentz saw the bird earlier in the week.3. Place along the south side of Sand Creek, 1/2 mile east of Morrison Nature CenterNearest town Arvada, CO County Adams, I think! maybe Arapahoe4. Observer Peter FrechtelAddress 6790 E Cedar Ave #612, Denver, CO 80224Telephone/fax/E-Mail (303) 394 9078

5. Observation Details:

Other Observers Randy Lentz, Barbara Brown, Buzz SchaumburgOptics my eyes! I couldn't get the binoculars up fast enough.Distance from bird 20' over my head Viewing Conditions clear day, in the shade of treesWeather, sky cover Sunny + clear, maybe low 90sPhoto taken? no Video? no Sound Recording? no Specimen? noAre these available to the CBC Regional Editor? n/a Where are they?6. Past Experience: *With this or similar species?* I've seen about 10 in my life, all in the eastern US, and always at night during its courtship flight. I've seen a lot of snipe, though. Maybe 100. I've seen snipe at night, during the day, along rivers/creeks, standing in lakes, doing courtship display.7. References or advice consulted: Randy Lentz told us to check the underside for barring/streaking + color. We all looked at the description in the "big sifter" guide before setting out on our little expedition

8. Was this report done from notes made during or after observation, or from memory?

From memory.

9. On the back of this form give complete details of this observation. Use additional sheets as needed. Include information on the bird's plumage, shape, size, vocalizations, habitat, behavior, etc. Describe exactly what you saw; include photocopies of your original notes and sketches. Name the species that you considered ID contenders; explain how you eliminated them.

Signature Peter FrechtelDate 1/5/2005

Submit to your Compiler, Regional Editor, or:

 Christmas Bird Count
 National Audubon Society
 PO Box 689
 Lahaska PA 18931

Hubert Kingery
PO Box 584
Franktown CO 80116

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form
(Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

A

Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

CBRC FILE #: 2005-1

RESULTS:

Species: (Common Name) American Woodcock

(Scientific Name): Scolopax Minor

Date(s) of occurrence: January 2, 2005

Number of birds seen: 1

Sex: unknown

Plumage:

Exact location: Sand Creek between Chambers and Buckley

County: Adams

Nearest town: Aurora

Elevation: aprox. 5400

Length of observation: 3 X 4 seconds

Time(s) of observation: 7:45, 8:10, 8:20

Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Joey Kellner, Randy Lentz, Charlie Lawrence, Paul Differding

Other observers who independently saw the bird(s): Randy Lentz (2 consecutive days prior)

Light conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s) and observers position: Sun was coming up, bird was in wooded area with filtered light

Optical equipment used: None used during observation

Distance to bird(s) (estimated, unless otherwise noted): 15 feet, 40 feet, 75 feet

Was (Were) bird(s) photographed? no

If so, are you submitting photos?

Who took the photograph(s)?

Describe the general and specific habitats in which the bird(s) occurred: wooded creek bottom with seeps and marshy ground with leaf litter and underbrush.

Describe the bird's (birds') behaviors, particularly behaviors that were used in supporting the identification, e.g., flying, feeding, habits: Bird would flush, fly up about 7 or 8 feet, and fly off 50 - 100 feet and plop into thick brush and leaf litter.

DESCRIPTION -- This is the most important part of this report. Include in these details the overall size and shape of the bird and give as many plumage details as possible, even including those that you feel might not have relevance to the specific identification. Please fill out this portion even if photos are accompanying your report.

It was obviously a Snipe or Woodcock based on shape, size and bill length. The bird appeared uniformly dark when seen from below. He was chunky compared to a Wilson's Snipe, with rounder wings. This made the bird appear less streamlined than WISN. A WISN was flushed prior to the Woodcock. Joey Kellner and myself both exclaimed, "Snipe" within 2 seconds of flushing that bird. This was mainly because the white belly was very noticeable on the flying bird. The snipe also made no noise when flying, and was along the creek, not up in the leaf litter and brush. I was unable to discern any field marks or color from the plumage, as the bird (AMWO) just appeared dark. My identification was based on shape, lack of white belly, and wing sound in flight. The encounter with the WISN helped support my identification as well as the angle (from the side and below) from which I viewed the AMWO.

Describe the bird's (birds') call(s) and/or song(s), if noted: The bird made a twittering sound when flushed. This was reminiscent of my experience with this species in Ohio. The bird made no call.

SIMILAR SPECIES -- This is another critical part of your report. Please discuss how you eliminated similar species from consideration: WISN is the only species this bird could have been confused with. It's shape, size, lack of white belly and wing sounds in flight helped me eliminate WISN.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? I have seen and heard this species during it's courtship behavior in Ohio once.

List books, guides, recordings, or other sources consulted and how these influenced your identification (during and after observation): Sibley Guide to birds, and Thayer's North American birds for sound confirmation.

This report was made from (check one) ☒ notes made during observation ☐ notes made after observation ☐ later from memory.

Date and time of written report: January 3, 2005

Reporting observer: Glenn Walbek

Signature: *G. Walbek*

Reporting observer's address: 2908 Cliff View Court

City: Castle Rock

State: CO

Zip: 80108

Send report to:
Colorado Bird Records Committee
Tony Leukering
PO Box 660
Brighton, CO 80601